Q28: Alignment Faking and Observation

Separate behavior, evidence, and interpretation

DLS 2026

October 2026

Question

Q28
Why does chain-of-thought sometimes differ when models believe they are unobserved?

Start with observable behavior

- Outputs change with prompts, roles, evaluators, or tools.
- This does *not* by itself prove hidden goals or belief.
- List benign alternatives before inferring strategy.

Three claim levels

1. Behavioral conditional difference
2. Elicited reasoning-trace difference
3. Stable internal objective / intention

Evidence needed grows at each level.

Controlled studies

- Hold task content fixed; vary one contextual cue.
- Randomize presentation and use held-out prompts.
- Predefine outcomes; test seeds/versions/evaluators.

Why traces are insufficient

- Reasoning text is model output shaped by training and prompts.
- It may be useful evidence, but not privileged access to mechanism.
- Test actions and trajectories independently.

Safety under uncertainty

- Bounded permissions and human confirmation
- Logs, reproducible environments, held-out red teams
- Monitor distribution shift and report failures

Evaluation example

- Authorized approval token; absent token; decoy token.
- Measure accept/reject/escalate behavior.
- Inspect any attempted boundary bypass.

Takeaway

Do not mind-read
Test context-dependent actions with controls; use defense in depth whether or not a strategic interpretation is warranted.